

KOMODO

& FLORES

THE LAND OF DRAGONS

A six-minute journey into Indonesia's wild frontier

NOT WRITTEN BY XAVIER BRUNELLE

A prehistoric horizon

Far beyond Bali and Lombok lies a landscape that feels almost prehistoric. Flores, Komodo, Rinca and their smaller neighbors sit within Wallacea, a biological crossroads between Asia and Australia. Tropical forest meets dry savannah; volcanic mountains rise above turquoise seas; and one of the world's most extraordinary animals survives much as it has for thousands of years.

Flores stretches roughly 350 kilometers from east to west. Rugged peaks, fertile valleys, traditional villages and dramatic coastlines reveal an island shaped by isolation. On its western shore, Labuan Bajo - once a quiet fishing village - has become the gateway to Komodo National Park.

The surrounding sea is just as remarkable. This is part of the Coral Triangle, where reefs support turtles, manta rays, dolphins, sharks and thousands of fish species. In Komodo, the story is never only about one animal. It is about an entire world of land and sea.

THE SETTING

Wallacea

Where Asian and Australian nature meet

Built for survival

The Komodo dragon, Varanus komodoensis, is the largest living lizard on Earth. Adult males can exceed three meters and weigh more than ninety kilograms. Muscular limbs, powerful claws, serrated teeth and armored skin reinforced with tiny bone deposits make it a formidable survivor.

Although often called a living dinosaur, it is actually a giant monitor lizard - the last surviving giant member of a lineage that once ranged across parts of Australia and Indonesia. On these isolated islands, with few other large predators, dragons evolved into the dominant hunters: the ecological equivalent of lions or wolves.

To meet one in the wild is to feel that evolution has briefly opened a window into another age.

LARGEST LIVING LIZARD

3+ meters

Exceptional adult males

How dragons hunt

A dragon's forked tongue constantly samples microscopic particles from the air. Jacobson's organ, in the roof of its mouth, analyzes them and allows the animal to detect carrion or prey from several kilometers away. In a very real sense, the dragon smells the world with its tongue.

Dragons are patient ambush predators. A mature animal may wait motionless near a game trail for hours, then explode forward with surprising speed. Its bite combines sharp, serrated teeth with venom that lowers blood pressure, reduces clotting and accelerates shock. If prey escapes, the dragon can follow the scent trail until blood loss and exhaustion take effect.

Once a kill is secured, an adult can consume up to eighty percent of its own body weight. Flexible skulls, expandable stomachs and powerful digestion allow dragons to swallow meat, bone and hide. At a carcass, size determines rank - and even smaller dragons may become prey.

ONE EXTRAORDINARY MEAL

Up to 80%

of its own body weight

The secret childhood

A female typically lays fifteen to thirty eggs in a nest dug into the ground or borrowed from a megapode bird. After roughly eight months, hatchlings emerge only about forty centimeters long - and immediately face danger.

Adult dragons, including unrelated animals and sometimes even their own mother, may see them as food. Young dragons survive by climbing. For their first several years, the forest canopy becomes both nursery and refuge. There they hunt insects, birds, eggs, rodents and small reptiles while avoiding the giants below.

Reproduction holds another surprise. Female Komodo dragons are capable of parthenogenesis: producing offspring without fertilization by a male. First documented in captivity, this rare ability may help the species colonize remote islands when mates are scarce.

As adults, dragons are largely solitary. During breeding season, rival males may rise on their hind legs and wrestle for access to females - an ancient contest of balance and strength.

The smallest dragons survive by leaving the ground behind.

8
MONTHS IN THE EGG

People and dragons

Humans have lived beside dragons for centuries. Local communities call them ora, and traditional stories often portray them as ancient inhabitants deserving respect. The relationship is not without risk: attacks are rare, but they do occur, and park rangers remain watchful.

The forked sticks carried by rangers began as defensive tools, designed to redirect a dragon's head if necessary. Today, trained guides, strict safety practices and carefully managed encounters protect visitors while minimizing disturbance to the animals.

Komodo National Park was established in 1980 and now protects more than 1,700 square kilometers of land and sea, including Komodo, Rinca and Padar. In 1991 it became a UNESCO World Heritage Site. What began as an effort to save one species grew into protection for coral reefs, mangroves, seagrass beds, marine mammals, birds and an entire island ecosystem.

A NAME FROM THE ISLANDS

ora

The local name for the dragon

Conservation and balance

Only an estimated 3,000 to 3,500 adult Komodo dragons survive in the wild. Their range is exceptionally small, leaving the species vulnerable to habitat change, declining prey, climate pressures and rising seas.

Tourism brings both opportunity and responsibility. Visitor revenue can support conservation, scientific research and local livelihoods. At the same time, rising numbers must be managed carefully so that the experience does not damage the fragile world people have come to see.

The dragon is often described as a relic from the age of dinosaurs. But that familiar comparison misses the more astonishing point: dinosaurs vanished sixty-six million years ago. The Komodo dragon survived.

Its future now depends on maintaining the balance between protection, community and discovery.

ESTIMATED WILD POPULATION

3,000-3,500

adult dragons

A small population. A responsibility shared by the world.

ONE LAST THOUGHT

The dragons continue to roam the dry hills and forests of Flores, Komodo and Rinca - a reminder that there are still places where nature writes the rules.

LOOK CLOSER

At the tongue tasting the air.

At the ranger reading the landscape.

At the ancient animal that learned to endure.

Welcome to the land of dragons.

Adapted from the supplied Komodo & Flores destination brochure

INDONESIA 2026